Marla, You're On

By Julianne Bernstein

INTRODUCTION

MARTHA: You know, this whole "audition" thing, really wears on you after a while. You wait and you wait and you wait until you get one maybe, minute-and-a-half shot to leave an impression on somebody who doesn't know or care who you are unless you can show them exactly what they want then and there. And then, one out of a million times…you get a call back. A wonderful, glorious call back. This just happens to be that one time, and tomorrow, I'll be prepared, I'll be ready for when that director to say "Mala, You're On" by Julianne Bernstein.

(MARLA enters clutching a script. She closes the door behind her, takes off her jacket. She crosses to the window, opens it a little, and looks out. She doesn't see what she is looking for so she crosses to the couch and settles herself down into it as if she is about to watch her favorite old movie and does not want to be disturbed.)

MARLA: *(Reading)* "The Center of My Soul: A Two-Character Play in Three Acts." One more. One more reading. And it's mine. *(She looks Stage Right toward the window. Crosses to it for a better view.)*

(Out the window) Damn! Thought maybe the police pulled you in by now. Well, get out of here you horny high-riser! You don't impress me. Go down to the diner on Seventy-ninth Street. Meet some of the customers I wait on. You'll see. Now, move away from there. Thank you! *(Toward the window)* Go park yourself in front of Sharon's apartment. She's probably prepping for tomorrow as well. No. She won't. I won't. I will not let Sharon Beedles get this part. I will not. I can understand her landing that national commercial. OK, she's the Madonna of Maiden form, there's no denying. But this part. No. I will not let Sharon Beedles get this part. The

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only other blond, five-foot, one-inch green-eyed* actress looking for work. And she happens to be queen of the D-cups. Probably has an agent handling each one. *(She takes off the note attached to the script and reads it.)*

"Miss Thompson. Read over act three, scene two for final reading tomorrow." Final reading. Final audition. Final chance at any part ever again. *(Pause)* No, Marla, stop this.

(Reading) Act three, scene two. "Elizabeth's bedroom. Elizabeth is seated on her bed with Victor looking down at her. She reaches up to Victor's face, pulling him down to her. They kiss." Nice, I like that. I can see it, too. *(As she reads the following line of dialog, MARLA's talent as an actress should reveal itself clearly. She is a very good one, who knows what she is doing.)*

(Still reading) "Don't go away this time. This is for you." *(She repeats the line as she crosses to the refrigerator exploring different ways of saying it. She looks toward the window shouting out the line exuberantly and confidently.)*

No! Not for *you!* This is for - what?! Binoculars?! Some help. *(She pulls down the shade.)*

(Reading) "She reaches up to Victor's face pulling him down to her. They

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kiss. They kiss again. She unbuttons her blouse, exposing her breasts." *(She stops. Rereads.)* " ... unbuttons... exposing her... " Oh. OK, her breasts. My... breasts. Yes. B-R-E-A-S-T *(Pause)* S. *(She rereads the note.)*

"Act three, scene two." Right. "Final reading... tomorrow." I'll give Sharon a call and congratulate her. *(Pause)* Wait a minute. It's only part of the scene. Just ... part of the scene. A natural part... of a scene. *(A man whistling from outside the window is heard. She runs over and lifts up the shade.)*

Hey! What are you whistling for? Maybe if you were serious, I'd - hey, you've been out there almost two weeks, now. The same thing every day for two weeks. Every single day. *(Softly)* Except for last Friday. What happened? *(Pause)* Nothing! Nothing! I didn't say... a thing. *(She pulls down the shade and goes back to the script and rereads it. She starts to unbutton her blouse saying the line "Don't go away this time. This is for you." She then tries to lift it over her head but stops midway.)*

Hey, uh ... I was going to call the police, but I-I'll give you a chance to explain first. *(Pause)* Well? *(Pause)* I see you scrapped the binoculars. You don't need them. I mean, there's only - *(Looking down)* - two taxi lanes between us. *(Pause)* And why don't you come out from around the side there? I mean, it looks like you're hiding ... or you're uncomfortable or something. Are you? Well ... uh ... see, I'm an actress, see, and I've

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almost got it. This part in this play. A real play in a theatre, you know? Finally. The thing is '" is that I have to take off my blouse. See, I need you to - You know, acting is really funny. Because most of the time when you're acting, it seems so real that it's not acting. it's more like... trying different ways to work out the same ... real... things. Oh, I don't know. You're disgusting. My boyfriend would never behave that way. Well, Bob's not exactly my boyfriend. He's this guy I've been seeing. For about three weeks now. Twice. I've been seeing him ... twice. Hey. Hey! *(She goes and picks up the phone.)*

Hi, Bob? It's me, Marla. You know. The casting call. The industrial for G.E. I read for the stupid housewife. Yeah. Yeah. *(Pause)* Right. I enjoyed it. I mean I thought they'd never call our numbers but I didn't mind waiting. Talking. Anyway, thanks for the coffee. Howard Johnson's across the street. Remember? *(Pause)* I can't believe I spent all my change on subway tokens. Anyway, I need someone to help me take off my blouse. No! I mean - what I mean is - there's this part. This scene. I mean - *(Pause)* Yeah. Me, too. I gotta go, too. Listen. *Uh...* maybe we'll see each other or something. Maybe we'll do lunch again. *(Pause)* Oh. No problem. I love that place. It was my pleasure. Yeah. *(She hangs up and looks out the window. Pause) Uh* ... wait a minute. Don't go away. *(She crosses away into her living room.)* No. I can't. He stares. A starer. Two weeks. All he's done is watch me. Look at me. And now he's ... doing the same thing. Watching ... looking ... *(She goes back over to the window.)*

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Hey, you changed your shirt. Nice shirt. I like the color. They call it rhubarb, I think. I love food colors. You know watermelon, tangerine, champagne... Anyway, I told Bob how I felt. That I thought that there was something really good between us and we should give it a shot. From the way his artichoke salad reappeared on his plate, I don't think he agreed. *(Pause)* See, it's a two-character play. Two people together ... on stage ... together. And in the third act, they're nude. Making love, I suppose. But not right there on stage, though. We allude to the fact. Suggest it, you know? See, acting isn't really acting. I mean, in the script the two characters ... don't ever really do it. They actually don't ever come close. Because the lights go black and they play is over. So if they don't ever do it, what the hell is the point? *(Pause)* Where are you going? Are you coming back? *(She remains at the window and waits for him to return.)*

I don't need him, anyway. *(She crosses to a record player.)*
Where's that old Sinatra record? *(She searches through a pile of records and pulls one out. She puts it on. It is old and scratched and it starts to skip. She takes the needle off, carelessly scratching the needle along the grooves.)*

Maybe the lights. *(She goes over to the lights and turns them off)*
No. Dim. Dim. Don't go completely off. *(She turns them back on.)*
I can't even set a mood. *(She goes back toward the window.)*

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Hey, there you are. I *am* going to get this job, tomorrow. Because I'm sick of staying home every Saturday night practically making love to a script. Yeah. I do. I mean, when I pick up a script, you know, I'm real gentle-like. You don't want to push anything. If it's not good ... right ... you don't want it. It feels wrong. Because it is wrong. Wrong. See, if you're good enough at what you're doing, you know, the acting - making the acting, real, and the real, actual. It's fantastic. Because you get to be so much like the role you're playing that in a lot of ways you're not really there. And you don't have to worry about anything. Even the morning after. You know, the sequel? When you turn over. The damp Sears pillow against your cheek. And you open your eyes and don't know where the hell you are, and that's when the camera's coming in for a close-up. The script. Right next to you. Between the sheets. Lying face up. Open to the last page of the scene you were working on the night before. Sometimes, though, it's closed. Back to the beginning. Page one. Staring you in the face. *(Pause)* Sorry. Show's over. You can go now. Sorry.

(She walks away from the window. She stops, picks up the script, turns back to the window, looks out and smiles a half smile of recognition and relief She takes a deep breath and the lights fade to black as she starts to unbutton her blouse, repeating the line, "Don 't go *away this time. This* is *for you.*")

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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